

How the Proof Works

Thomas Birnie

The three-dimensional Navier–Stokes regularity problem asks whether a smooth solution can lose its smoothness in finite time. Fix a smooth, divergence-free datum u_0 and a viscosity $\nu > 0$.

Take a vortex tube as the physical picture. As it stretches and thins, the fluid around its shrinking core turns faster and faster, and the velocity changes across a smaller distance. The tube cannot lengthen without becoming narrower.

To see where that concentration sits in the Sobolev scale, rescale the fluid:

$$u_\lambda(x, t) = \lambda u(\lambda x, \lambda^2 t), \quad \|u_\lambda(t)\|_{\dot{H}^s} = \lambda^{s-1/2} \|u(\lambda^2 t)\|_{\dot{H}^s}.$$

Below $s = \frac{1}{2}$, concentration makes the Sobolev norm smaller. Above $s = \frac{1}{2}$, it makes the norm larger. At $s = \frac{1}{2}$, the power of λ disappears. The exponent vanishes between the energy level below it and the first-derivative level above it. That unchanged middle level is the critical height. At this height, viscosity and nonlinear transport have equal scaling weight.

The kinetic energy can remain finite while smaller and smaller regions carry steeper gradients.

In order for a singularity to form, velocity has to blow up. In order for that to happen, its acceleration would also have to blow up, which means its jerk has to blow up, and so on, and so on:

$$u, \quad \partial_t u, \quad \partial_t^2 u, \quad \dots$$

If a singularity were forming, what we would expect to see as we move up those time derivatives is less spatial regularity, not more.

What the time derivatives reveal

Write out the first three derivatives:

$$\begin{aligned}\partial_t u &= \nu \Delta u - (u \cdot \nabla)u - \nabla p, \\ \partial_t^2 u &= \nu \Delta \partial_t u - (\partial_t u \cdot \nabla)u - (u \cdot \nabla) \partial_t u - \nabla \partial_t p, \\ \partial_t^3 u &= \nu \Delta \partial_t^2 u - (\partial_t^2 u \cdot \nabla)u - 2(\partial_t u \cdot \nabla) \partial_t u \\ &\quad - (u \cdot \nabla) \partial_t^2 u - \nabla \partial_t^2 p.\end{aligned}$$

By the third line, the nonlinear term is visibly branching. The binomial form writes the complete expansion at once:

$$\begin{aligned}\partial_t^{r+1} u + \sum_{a=0}^r \binom{r}{a} ((\partial_t^a u) \cdot \nabla) \partial_t^{r-a} u + \nabla \partial_t^r p \\ = \nu \Delta \partial_t^r u.\end{aligned}$$

Set

$$V_r := \partial_t^r u, \quad Q_r := \partial_t^r p.$$

Write $\Lambda := (-\Delta)^{1/2}$, so that Λ^s measures s spatial derivatives. At any finite time-derivative order r and spatial height s , set

$$E_{r,s}(t) := \frac{1}{2} \|\Lambda^s V_r(t)\|_2^2.$$

Pair the r -th differentiated equation with $\Lambda^{2s} V_r$, and collect the transport and pressure terms in $\mathcal{P}_{r,s}$. Viscosity gives

$$E'_{r,s} = \mathcal{P}_{r,s} - 2\nu E_{r,s+1}.$$

The coefficient 2ν links spatial height s to height $s+1$. For each pair (r, s) , r chooses a time derivative and s chooses the Sobolev height at which it is measured. These are the two directions of the mixed grid. For $r=0$, set $H := E_{0,1/2}$. This is the critical height identified above, so

$$H' = \mathcal{P}_{0,1/2} - 2\nu E_{0,3/2}.$$

After n time derivatives,

$$\frac{d^n H}{dt^n} = (-2\nu)^n E_{0,n+1/2} + \sum_{j=0}^{n-1} (-2\nu)^j \partial_t^{n-1-j} \mathcal{P}_{0,j+1/2}.$$

The highest term is the Sobolev energy at height $n + \frac{1}{2}$. As temporal order rises, Sobolev height rises with it. That is the reversal. We followed velocity, acceleration, jerk, and everything above them expecting spatial regularity to fall away. Navier–Stokes points upward through the Sobolev scale.

In three dimensions, the Sobolev embedding theorem gives

$$s > k + \frac{3}{2} \implies H^s(\mathbb{R}^3) \hookrightarrow C^k(\mathbb{R}^3), \quad \bigcap_{m < \infty} H^m(\mathbb{R}^3) = H^\infty(\mathbb{R}^3) \hookrightarrow C^\infty(\mathbb{R}^3).$$

Higher time derivatives have opened higher Sobolev embeddings. If every finite height reaches T_* , then every finite spatial derivative reaches it too.

How the heights reach the endpoint

The calculation has exposed the height. To carry it all the way to T_* , choose a finite temporal depth N and a finite spatial height M . For each $n \leq N$, the adjacent pair

$$V_n \in L_t^2 H_x^{M+1}, \quad V_{n+1} = \partial_t V_n \in L_t^2 H_x^{M-1} \implies V_n \in C_t H_x^M$$

carries the middle spatial height continuously to T_* . Stacking finitely many of these rows gives $\mathcal{R}_{N,M}[u_0]$.

The whole-terminal rectangle theorem supplies that finite block for every finite (N, M) . All of the blocks come from the fluid generated by u_0 , so their shared entries agree. They fit together in $\mathcal{I}[u_0]$, whose velocity belongs to

$$\bigcap_{r, m < \infty} H^r(0, T_*; H^m(\mathbb{R}^3)).$$

This is the intersection between the time derivatives and the spatial derivatives. It contains every finite height exposed by the calculation above.

Its zeroth temporal row is $\mathcal{S}_0 := \pi_0 \mathcal{I}[u_0]$, and its endpoint is

$$u_* := u(T_*) \in \bigcap_{m < \infty} H^m(\mathbb{R}^3) = H^\infty(\mathbb{R}^3) \hookrightarrow C^\infty(\mathbb{R}^3).$$

The singularity picture called for spatial regularity to disappear as the time derivatives rose. The intersection reaches T_* with every finite spatial height intact.

Local smooth existence continues the fluid from u_* through $[T_*, T_* + \delta]$, and uniqueness joins that continuation to the fluid we started with. A finite maximal time can be crossed, so

$$T_* = \infty.$$

Where the estimates come from

Once the intersection contains every finite Sobolev height, choose whichever height a particular estimate asks for. Three familiar choices are

$$\begin{aligned}\mathcal{I}[u_0] &\longrightarrow C_t H_x^1 \longrightarrow L_t^\infty L_x^6, \\ \mathcal{I}[u_0] &\longrightarrow C_t H_x^2 \longrightarrow L_t^\infty L_x^\infty, \\ \mathcal{I}[u_0] &\longrightarrow C_t H_x^3 \longrightarrow L_t^\infty W_x^{1,\infty}.\end{aligned}$$

The third line, for example, gives on any finite interval $[0, T]$

$$\int_0^T \|\nabla u(t)\|_{L^\infty} dt \leq CT \sup_{0 \leq t \leq T} \|u(t)\|_{H^3} < \infty.$$

For any other finite demand, ask how many derivatives and which spatial norm it needs. Choose a Sobolev height above that demand, and the intersection supplies the estimate.

The familiar continuation estimates are read from the intersection afterward. They are derived from u_0 through the intersection, not the other way around.

The entire proof can now be read in one line:

$$\begin{aligned}u_0 &\longrightarrow \{(V_n, Q_n)\}_{n \geq 0} \longrightarrow \{\mathcal{R}_{N,M}[u_0]\}_{N,M < \infty} \longrightarrow \mathcal{I}[u_0] \\ &\longrightarrow \mathcal{S}_0 \longrightarrow u_* \in H^\infty \longrightarrow T_* = \infty.\end{aligned}$$